



lolite

△ **Unusual**, round, step-cut lolite gem

Gem-quality blue cordierite is known as lolite, derived from a Greek word meaning “violet”, a reference to its colour. As a gemstone, it is particularly noted for its pleochroism, appearing intense blue in one direction, yellowish-grey or blue in another, and almost colourless as the stone is turned in the third direction. It is almost always faceted, and cutters need to take careful note of the orientation of the stone to obtain the best colour. Another informal name applied to lolite is “water sapphire”, again because of its colour.

Specification

Chemical name Magnesium, iron aluminosilicate | **Formula** $(\text{Mg,Fe})_2\text{Al}_4\text{Si}_5\text{O}_{18}$ | **Colours** Blue | **Structure** Orthorhombic | **Hardness** 7–7.5 | **SG** 2.6 | **RI** 1.53–1.55 | **Lustre** Vitreous to greasy | **Streak** Colourless | **Locations** Sri Lanka, India, Canada, Myanmar, Madagascar



lolite in matrix | **Rough** | This matrix specimen contains numerous gem-quality, dark lolite crystals studded within a quartz groundmass.

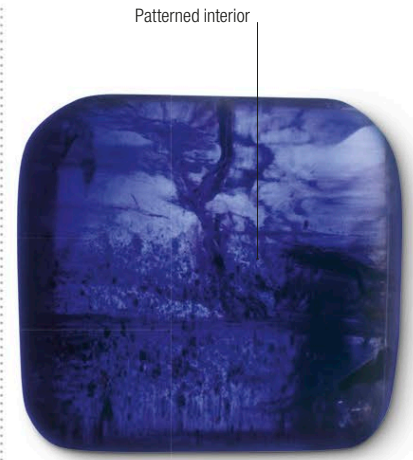


Oval brilliant | **Cut** | The fine, sapphire-blue colour of lolite is beautifully displayed in this oval brilliant, and illustrates its informal name of “water sapphire”.



Finely carved eye

Tiny marks on surface



Patterned interior

lolite cabochon | **Cut** | Although not usually thought of as cabochon material, this rich blue gem shows that lolite can be cut *en cabochon* with dramatic results.

The many names of lolite

Obsolete and current

lolite is a good example of how gemstone names evolve. “Water sapphire” may have originated because the stone was usually found in water, for example in the gem gravels of Sri Lanka and Myanmar. Another old name is dichroite, a Greek word meaning “two-coloured rock”, a reference to its pleochroism. Yet another obsolete name for lolite is steinheilite, after Fabian Steinheil, the Russian military governor of Finland, who first observed that it was a mineral distinct from quartz.



Sri Lankan scene A print showing Kelani Ganga River in Sri Lanka, a source of lolite gem gravels.



Tourmaline “petals”

lolite carving | **Carved** | lolite is seldom used as a carving material. This charming dog weighs 39.16 carats and is part of a set of various gemstone animal carvings.

lolite earrings | **Set** | These flower earrings set in 18-karat yellow gold each feature a central, step-cut lolite, with pink tourmalines forming the “petals”.